

Finland



Area 130,128 sq miles
(337,030 sq km)
Population 5.4 million
Capital Helsinki
Currency Euro
Official languages Finnish
and Swedish
Life expectancy 79 years



A country of forests and 187,888 lakes, Finland is bordered on the north and west by Norway and Sweden. To its east lies Russia, which ruled Finland from 1809 until 1917, when Finland became a republic. It joined the EU in 1995 and

adopted the Euro (the official currency of the EU) in 2002. Finnish women have long been involved in the running of the country. They were the first in Europe, in 1906, to get the right to vote and the first in the world to be able to run for parliament. Finland has a large high-tech sector, which includes the mobile phone company Nokia.

► REINDEER IN LAPLAND

In Lapland, in northern Finland, reindeer are herded by the Sami people, who use the animal's meat for food and its hide for clothing and shelter.



Estonia



Area 17,462 sq miles
(45,226 sq km)
Population 1.3 million
Capital Tallinn
Currency Euro
Official language Estonian
Life expectancy 73 years



After decades of Soviet rule, Estonia gained its independence in 1991. Its terrain is flat, boggy, and partly wooded, and includes more than 1,500 islands. Estonia's chief energy resource is oil shale, a rock from which oil is extracted. However, industrial pollution from power plants burning oil shale has now become a growing concern.

Latvia



Area 24,938 sq miles
(64,589 sq km)
Population 2.2 million
Capital Riga
Currency Latvian lats
Official language Latvian
Life expectancy 71 years



Latvia is one of the three Baltic countries (along with Estonia and Lithuania) that gained independence from the Communist Soviet Union in 1991. The Latvian economy is dominated by the service sector, though agriculture continues to play an important role. More than 25 percent of the population is ethnically Russian.

Lithuania



Area 25,174 sq miles
(65,200 sq km)
Population 3.3 million
Capital Vilnius
Currency Lithuanian litas
Official language Lithuanian
Life expectancy 71 years



Lying on the eastern coast of the Baltic Sea, Lithuania is the largest of the three Baltic countries. It was the last European country to formally embrace Christianity, around 1400 CE. Its terrain is mostly flat, with many lakes, moors, and bogs. A member of the EU since 2004, Lithuania intends to adopt the Euro in 2013.

Denmark



Area 16,639 sq miles
(43,094 sq km)
Population 5.6 million
Capital Copenhagen
Currency Danish krone
Official language Danish
Life expectancy 78 years



With one of the flattest terrains in the world, Denmark is the southernmost country in Scandinavia. It occupies most of the Jutland (Jylland) peninsula and includes the islands of Sjælland, Fyn, Lolland, and Falster, and more than 400 smaller islands. Two self-governing nations lying in the North Atlantic, the Faeroe

Islands and Greenland, fall under the sovereignty of Denmark. The population is largely of Danish ethnicity with small minorities of Turks and Inuit, Greenland's indigenous inhabitants. Denmark's income distribution is the most even among Western countries, with most Danes able to live comfortably. Denmark is also a strong supporter of developing countries, especially in Africa.

► THE LITTLE MERMAID

This iconic statue of a mermaid in Copenhagen is based on the fairy tale The Little Mermaid by the Danish author Hans Christian Andersen.

